

who had met Whistler, also used the word “Nocturne” in his designation for a series of musical works and drew great inspiration from the artist’s paintings in the creation of his music.

The Symbolist movement

Debussy had closer links with the literary and artistic movement known as Symbolism than he ever had with Impressionism.

Symbolists avoided formal structures, such as specific subjects or plots. Theirs was an art of nuance and suggestion, as they created moods, emotions, or ideas. Debussy had important links with two Symbolist writers—the poet Stéphane Mallarmé and the dramatist Maurice Maeterlinck. He met Mallarmé in 1890 and regularly attended the famous Tuesday salons at which the writer hosted visitors including W.B. Yeats, Rainer Maria Rilke, and Paul Verlaine.

**“ Music is the arithmetic of sounds as
optics is the geometry of light. ”**

CLAUDE DEBUSSY

Literary influences

Greatly inspired by Mallarmé’s verses, Debussy produced *Prélude à l’après-midi d’un faune* (1894). This highly sensual symphonic poem, conjuring up the lust-filled dreams of the creature on a hot day (see box), made little impact at the time, but